

Prehistoric sites of human ancestors in Africa.



Fossils of Lucy (Australopithecus)

Hominid refers to all the species of the modern and extinct great apes, which also includes humans.

Hominins (a zoological tribe) refers to the close relatives of human ancestors and their sister species including *Homo sapiens* (the modern humans) and the extinct members of *Homo neanderthalensis*, *Homo erectus, Homo habilis* and various species of *Australopithecines*. Humans are the only living species of this 'tribe'. They stand erect, walk with two legs and have large brains. They can use tools and a few of them can communicate. It excludes the gorillas.

Homo habilis (handy human) was the earliest known human ancestors to make tools in Africa about 2.6 million years ago. Around 2 million years ago, the species of *Homo erectus/ergaster* emerged. This species made hand axes between 2 and 1 million years ago. They began to spread into various parts of Asia and Africa in time.

Anatomically, modern humans, called *Homo sapiens* (wise man), first appeared around 3,00,000 years ago in Africa. It is believed that these modern humans eventually migrated and dispersed into various parts of the world from around 60,000 years ago.

Prehistoric Cultures

Prehistoric period does not have evidence of writing. While the fossil bones are classified as various species such as *Homo habilis*, *Homo erectus* and *Neanderthalensis*, based on the lithic tools, cultures are assigned names such as Earliest Lithic Assemblages, Oldowan Technology, Lower, Middle and Upper Paleolithic and Mesolithic cultures.



The chimpanzee and the pygmy chimpanzee (also known as bonobo) are our closest living relatives.

Earliest Lithic Assemblages of Human Ancestors

The earliest tools made by human ancestors are found in Lomekwi in Kenya. They are dated to 3.3 million years. Oldowan tools occur in the Olduvai gorge in Africa. They are 2 to 2.6 million years old. The human ancestors (Australopithecines) used hammer stones and produced sharp-edged flakes. The tools were used for cutting, slicing and processing food.

Lower Paleolithic Culture

The Lower Paleolithic Culture is marked by the human ancestors belonging to the species Homo habilis and Homo erectus. The human ancestors flaked large stone blocks and designed various tools including hand axes. These tools, which are found in Africa, Asia, and Europe, are dated the earliest to about 1.8 million years ago. They made various tools such as hand axes and cleavers to meet their subsistence needs. These tools are also known as bifaces. These tools have physical symmetry and convey the humans' cognitive (perception) skills. This culture is called the Lower Paleolithic Culture. The hand axe tools are also known as Acheulian. This tool-making tradition continued till 250,000 years to 60,000 years ago in India.

Acheulian – They were first hand axes recognized at a place called St. Acheul in France. Hence they are called Acheulian tools.

Bifaces are tools that have flaking on both sides (bi = two, face = side).

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